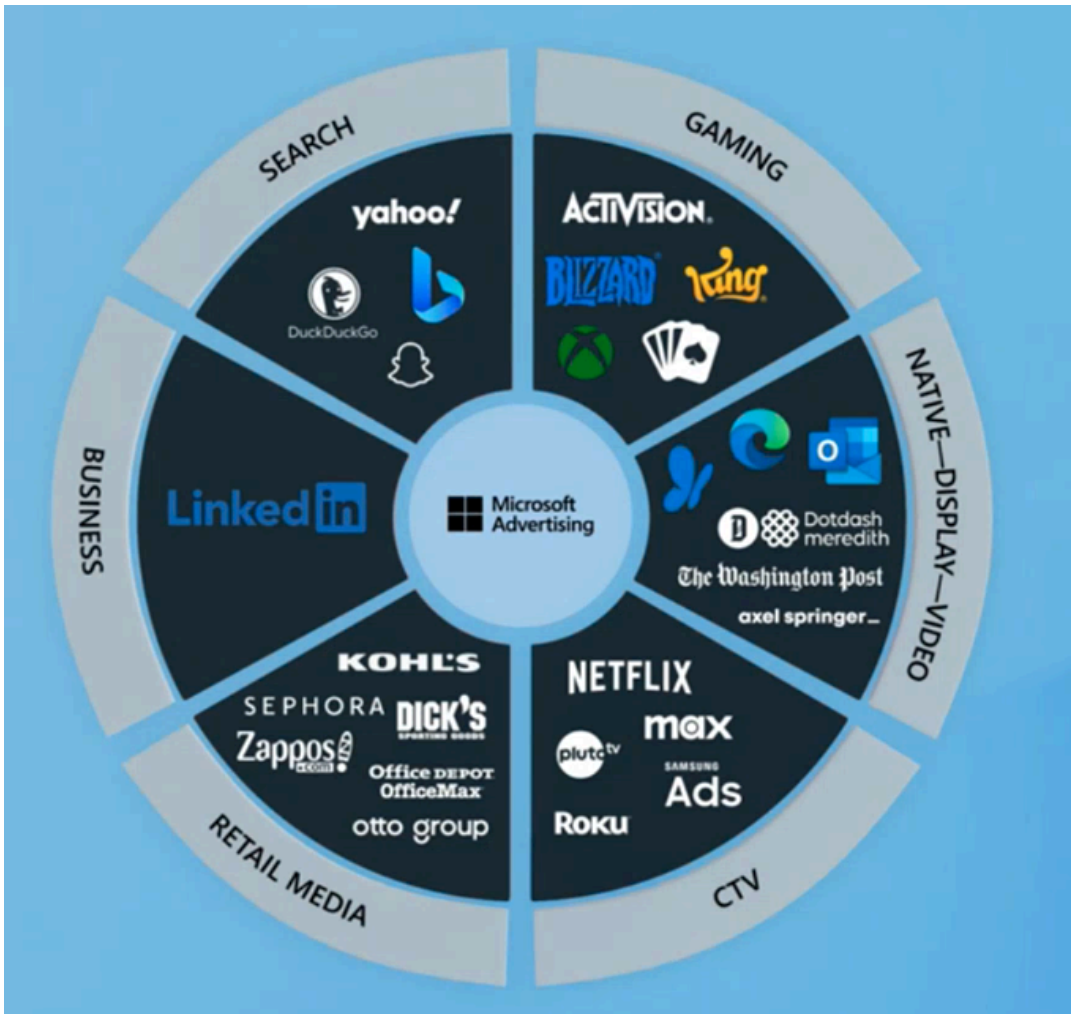
AI Driven Remediation for Ads Policy Violations for SMB Advertisers

By Kedarnath Kulkarni (x17kedarnath@iima.ac.in)

Context

In FY 2024, Microsoft Advertising reached over **1 billion users** across the globe, helped **millions of enterprises and SMBs** grow their business, and earned over **$12 billion** in revenue. To accomplish this, Microsoft Advertising operates a comprehensive network of digital properties as shown below -



Source: MSFT Webinar

A fundamental pillar of this global, high scale ads business is trust. Key ecosystem stakeholders such as users, advertisers/ brands, and publishers trust Microsoft Advertising to protect them from unsafe (or inappropriate) content, and harmful post click experiences. The Trust & Safety (T&S) organization plays a key role in maintaining a healthy ecosystem while enabling Microsoft Advertising's mission of empowering growth for businesses of all sizes. To accomplish this, the T&S org uses the below key levers -

1. **Automated enforcement of ads policies -** Leveraging AI/ML to ensure
    - Participants and the creative components (image, text, trackers, URLs etc) they use comply with the relevant ads policies.
    - Bad actors (advertisers or publishers) and unsafe content are identified and prevented from causing harm.
2. **Human review & appeals -** A human operations team to
    - Review case violations and appeals, and implement a three-strikes enforcement model to block bad actors.
    - Correct false positive and flag false negative outputs from the automated AI/ ML pipeline while providing useful training data for the models.

The T&S org trades revenue loss (by blocking business from bad actors) for long term sustainable growth by increasing trust in the ecosystem. To get a competitive perspective, in 2024 Google ads suspended over 39M advertiser accounts, removed or restricted over 14B ads, and blocked ads on over 1B publisher pages.

Problem Space

A self-serve ads manager coupled with high reach digital properties has enabled Microsoft advertising to scale globally. But with this scale comes the increased risk from bad actors. Trust and safety in the Microsoft advertising ecosystem has to be built on both the demand side as well as supply side.

On the **demand side**, it involves

a. **Fighting advertiser fraud** at scale using signals such as business impersonation, illegitimate payment information, inaccurate information or documentation.

b. **Creative content compliance** with the ads policies to
    i. Protect users from inappropriate or harmful experiences such as adult content, fraud, malicious software, and scams.
    ii. Prevent Microsoft, genuine advertisers, and publishers from risks such as losing their reputation, violating regional laws, trademark or copyright infringement.

On the **supply side**, it involves

a. Identifying and blocking **invalid traffic** to ensure the ads brands pay for are seen by real humans and not bots.
b. Ensuring the ads show up against content that is **brand safe** and aligned with advertiser's content policies.

In short, ensure **publishers (supply side)** can safely monetise their content with ads, get **advertisers (demand side)** a high ROI on their ad spend, all while **users** get a safe experience with ads that are compliant with policies and laws.

Opportunity and User segments

Microsoft Advertising is not supply constrained as it has high volume, high quality, brand safe ad inventory via owned and operated properties (Bing, MSN, Edge, Outlook, Xbox etc) and partnerships (Yahoo, AOL, other retail media etc). Hence, in terms of prioritisation, it makes sense to focus first on the demand side problems.

On the demand side, advertisers often face ad rejections due to violations of policies around content, targeting, or disclosures. However, not all violations of policy are driven by ill intent on the part of advertisers. **Unblocking such advertisers with no malintent**, whose ads are disapproved because of violations of ads policies represents a **favorable risk benefit trade off** as it means unlocking a safe ads experience for users, empowering business growth for advertisers, and revenue for Microsoft advertising. However, the current experience of unblocking such advertisers is opaque leading to frustrated and confused clients as seen below -

My manager account has been blocked by Microsoft ads and I don't know why, is there any way to unblock it (identify the cause of the policy violation)?

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Jun 12, 2024 at 12:12 PM

We haven't had any problems running advertisements the past few months, but recently when we try to import a new advertisement from Google Ads, it gets blocked.

We have no idea what policy we have violated and do not know what to fix.

Any information would be appreciated.

NK Nick Kuchinski

Created on October 17, 2024

Violation of Egregious Policy

This is the email I received from Microsoft Advertising. I have tried to reach out for more clarity around this to no avail. Phone support has been unhelpful and frankly rude. I believe the automated system and review process is broken and our account was flagged by a false positive result.

To delve deeper into the problem of ad rejections, let us view it from the lens of advertiser segments to identify who is most affected by it.

a. **Enterprise clients, media agencies, and large D2C advertisers** are either less likely to run into policy violations or more likely to have the expertise to take corrective actions.
b. **SMBs** don't have policy experts on hand to resolve account suspension or creative disapprovals resulting in delays, lost revenue, and poor trust in the platform. These advertisers want to know: "What exactly went wrong, and how can I fix it quickly?".
c. *[Data point - distribution of # of advertisers, # of ads, and campaign budget on hold split by above advertiser segments.]*

MVP Segment

Thus, we should prioritize the SMB segment and help them correct the policy violations for the following reasons -

a. **Alignment with Microsoft Advertising's mission** - *To empower businesses to connect with their audiences in meaningful ways, leveraging technology and innovation to create impactful advertising experiences.*
    i. An AI-driven auto-fix flow helps accomplish this mission, turning opaque rejections into guided fixes and accelerating SMB campaign success.
b. **SMB Dominance**: SMBs comprise over 60% of Microsoft Advertising accounts, collectively contributing a significant share of the $12 billion in annual ad spend.
    i. Transparent remediation will build stickiness within the high-growth SMB segment.
c. Benefits to Microsoft Advertising -
    i. Faster approvals will unlock delayed or unrealised ad spend, that can run into millions of dollars per quarter.
    ii. Reduction in cost of operations [*currently at $XX M*] and turn around time of customer support involving human reviews.
d. **Alignment with Microsoft's strengths** -
    i. **Copilot integration**: Deep LLM expertise to generate contextual, policy-compliant edit suggestions.
    ii. **Rich enforcement data**: Access to a huge amount of historical policy enforcement events for model training.

User Pain Points

E2E SMB Campaign Journey

To understand the user pain points, let us understand the user journey and the use cases for which they use the Microsoft advertising platform. Here is the quick overview -

#	Step	Description
1	Account Creation	Sign up or log in to the Microsoft Advertising Platform
2	Start Campaign	Click “Create Campaign”
3	Set Goal (Use Cases)	Choose campaign objective (Conversion, Leads, Awareness, Product sales, App Installs)
4	Campaign Type	Select Search, Audience, Performance, or Shopping Ads
5	Campaign Settings	Name, budget, bidding strategy, location, language
6	Ad Groups/Keywords	Organize by theme, add relevant keywords with match types
7	Create Ads	Write headlines, descriptions, set CTAs, URLs, add images, videos, logos
8	Targeting/Schedule	Set demographics, ad schedule, and audience targeting
9	Conversion Tracking	Install UET tag
10	Publish Campaign	Final review, save, and publish campaign
11	Content Review and Approval	Automated + human review of creative content and decision
12	Launch Campaign	Get approval via appeal or correct the violations and launch campaign

Key pain points/ blockers

Sticking to our scope of unblocking advertisers with no malintent, here are the key areas of ads policy violations leading to disapprovals -

1. **Clickbait & Misrepresentation**
    - **Issue:** Creative that overpromises or sensationalizes ("You won't believe how low these prices are!"). Per policy, ads must accurately reflect the product or offer and avoid misleading sensationalist language.
    - **Impact:** SMBs without copywriting or legal teams repeatedly shuffle wording in hopes of approval, adding hours of delay per campaign.
2. **Domain & URL Mismatch**
    - **Issue:** The **Display URL** (what's shown) -
        - doesn't share the same domain as the **Final URL** (where the click lands) or doesn't belong to the advertiser's verified web property.
        - has a landing page that doesn't align with the ad's product leading to a "Destination Mismatch".
    - **Impact:** SMBs using third-party landing pages, link shorteners, or incorrect tracking templates must troubleshoot URL structures and re-submit, costing days of lost impressions.
3. **Falling short on media format requirements**
    - **Images and videos** that do not meet Microsoft ads requirements of being high-quality, relevant, clearly legible, appropriate for all audiences, having proper format and presentation (like clear borders and accurate brand use) with no crude, political, hateful or overly sexualized imagery content.

Coupled with the current vague and opaque reasons, ads disapprovals lead to the following **pain points for the SMB advertisers** -

1. Not having clarity on exactly which ads of the campaign are disapproved.
2. Not knowing the specific reasons for disapproval or the policies the ads violated.
3. Lacking the know-how, bandwidth, or dedicated resources to fix the ads and get the campaign up and running.

The current policy violation messaging leads to a frustrating sequence of events for SMB advertisers - ***Generic rejections*** → ***manual policy research*** → ***repeated edits*** → ***multi-day campaign holds.***

Solving for the above pain points would differ by the areas of violations, thus it is advisable to prioritise and accomplish business impact in quick and regular intervals.

Prioritization matrix

Ad Policy Violation Area	Risk to end users & publishers	# of advertisers Impacted	Solution Effort
Clickbait & Misrepresentation	Medium	Medium	Low
Domain & URL Mismatch	High	High	Medium
Non compliant Images and videos	High	Low	High

Primary pain to solve: Provide clear, contextual remediation for clickbait/misrepresentation and URL/domain mismatches directly in the UI.

Product Goals & Success Vision

Enable SMB advertisers to self-remediate policy violations via AI-powered edit recommendations, restoring ad approvals and trust.

- **Approval Velocity**: 80% of auto-fixed ads approved within 2 hours of recommendation.
- **First-Time Accuracy**: ≥80% of suggested edits accepted on first resubmission.
- **Engagement**: ≥50% of SMBs encountering rejections adopt the auto-fix flow.

Features & MVP Prioritization

#	Feature	High Level Description	Placement
1	**Clickbait Detection & Rewrite**	**Policy-Aware Copy Analyzer** flags sensationalist phrases (e.g. "You won't believe...!"). **Auto-Rewrite Suggestions**: Proposes compliant alternatives that accurately describe the product (e.g. "Shop new summer styles at 25% off").	Ads detail page
2	**URL Compliance Checker**	**Domain Validator** ensures the Display URL and Final URL share the advertiser's verified domain. **Auto-Correction Prompts**: If mismatched, suggests swapping in the correct domain or offers to strip unsafe tracking parameters.	Ads detail page
3	**Rejection Insight Panel**	**Enumerates all triggered policies at an ad level** - including misrepresentation and destination requirements - each with a brief excerpt.	1/ Ads listing grid/ library 2/ Ads list in the campaign
4	**One-Click Re-apply & Preview**	**Applies copy rewrites or URL corrections** into the advertiser made selection of disapproved ad(s). Displays live "policy risk score" before re-submission.	1/ Ads listing grid/ library 2/ Ads list in the campaign

5	**Copilot powered Explanations**	Natural-language rationale for each clickbait or URL suggestion, citing the exact policy clause.	Info icon modal in the ads detail page
6	**Feedback Loop**	Advertisers can up-vote/down-vote individual suggestions to continuously refine the copy and URL models.	Next to the suggestion in the ads detail page
7	**Copilot powered chat for disapproved ads remediation**	Conversation style remediation that for example starts with the advertiser asking “which of my ads are not approved?” followed by “Show me how to fix it” which then prompts the recommender to show fix suggestions.	Copilot modal in the microsoft advertising platform

Roadmap and Milestones

- **Now (MVP)**:
    1. Rejection Insight Panel
    2. URL Compliance Checker
- **Next**
    1. Clickbait Detection & Rewrite
    2. Feedback Loop
- **Later**
    1. One-Click Re-apply & Preview
    2. Copilot powered chat for disapproved ads remediation
    3. AI powered auto fix suggestions for image and video assets

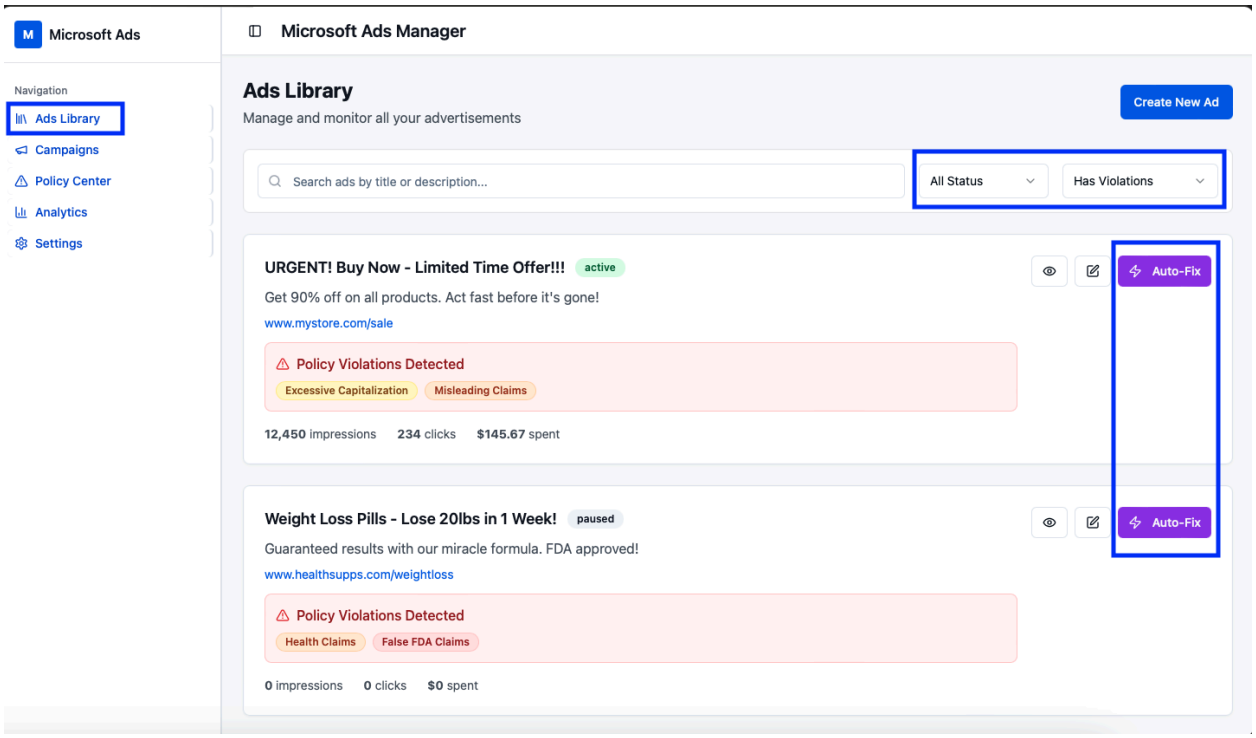
Rationale

- **Strategic Impact**:
    1. Optimise for ROI across stakeholders - by prioritising domain and URL mismatch issue that poses high risk for users, affects the majority of SMB advertisers, and needs medium effort to solve.

2. Then pick the low hanging fruit of Clickbait Detection & Rewrite that affects the next highest number of SMB advertisers.
3. With learning, feedback, and training data available from the iterative product launches addressing text and URL mismatch; we can more confidently tackle the issue for images and video assets.

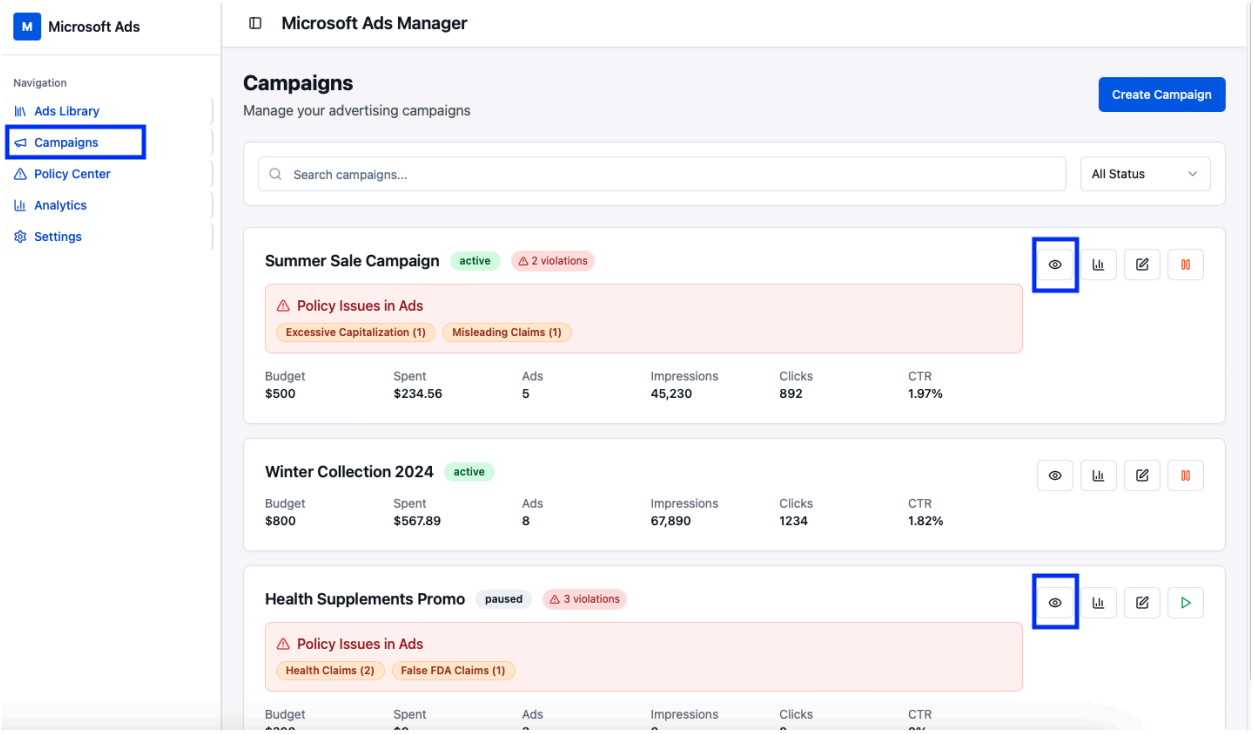
Feature Mocks and User Journeys

1. Get a **holistic view of all the problematic ads in the ads library** with
    a. details on the policy violation and a button to auto-fix that would...
    b. ...redirect the SMB advertiser to the ads detail page where the suggestions would be listed for the field(s) in question.

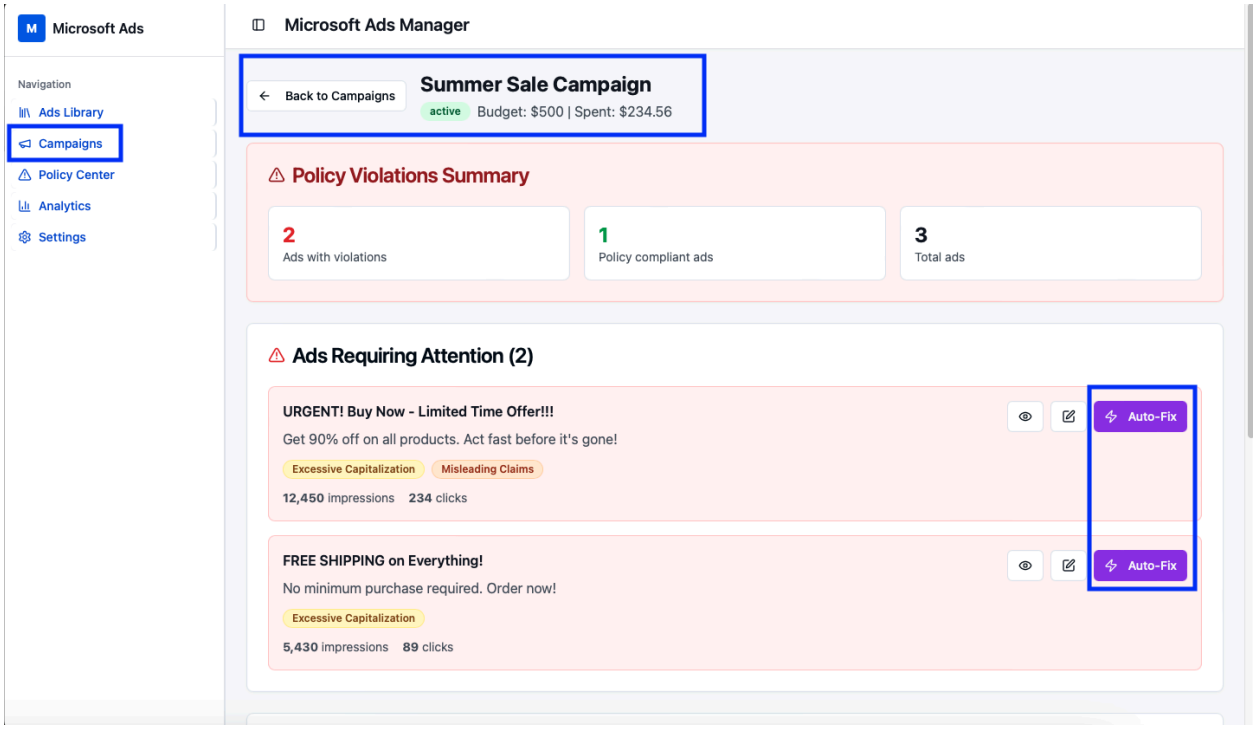


2. Get a view of
    a. **which campaigns are affected by policy violations** along with a summary of violations (#, policies violated etc).
    b. SMB advertisers can then click on the 'eye' icon to go into the ads listing page for the campaign and auto-fix each affected ad.

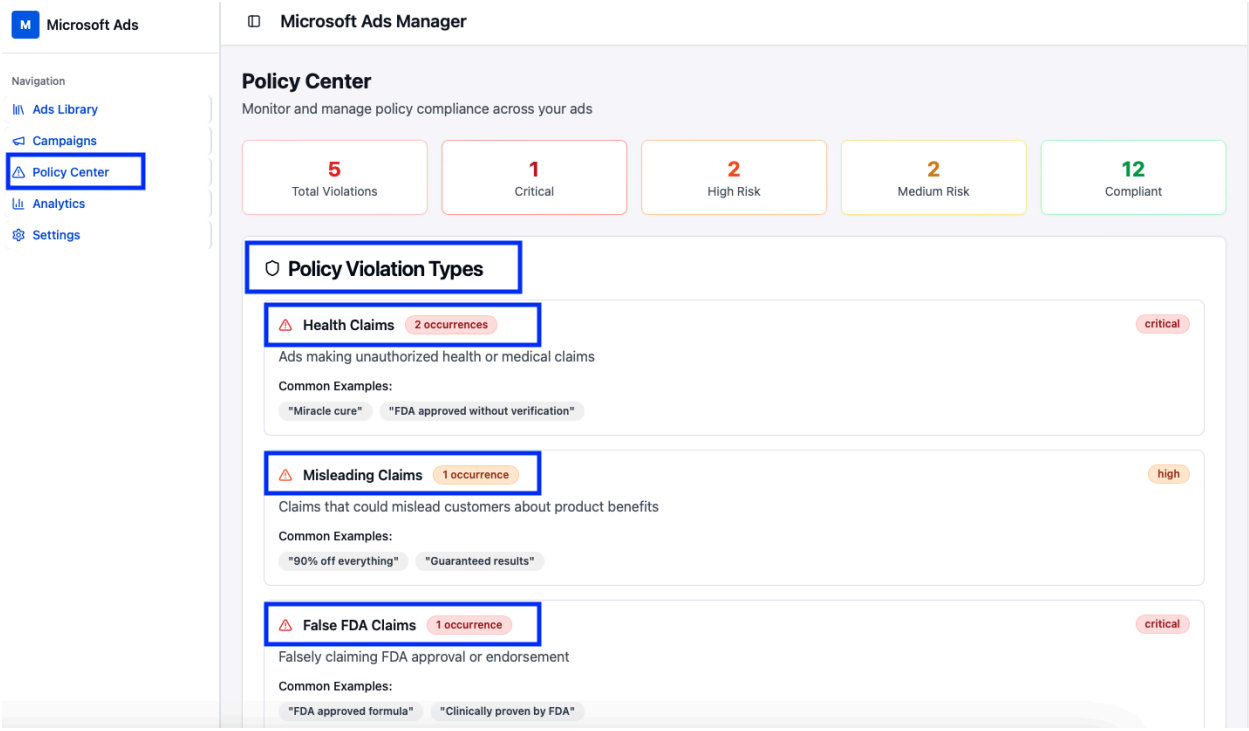
a. Campaign Level View of policy violations



b. Auto-fix ads within the campaign



3. **Rejection Insight Panel** - to get a view
    a. of the ads in violation of the policies grouped by the policy violated.
    b. SMB advertisers can click on the policy and get to a grid of ads in violation of the policy and click on the auto-fix button next to each ad.



Success Metrics & Risks

Success Metrics

Priority	Metric
P0	% of suggested fixes approved on first resubmission
P0	% of SMBs facing disapprovals adopting auto fix recommender
P1	Incremental ad spend recovered per month
P1	Avg. time saved per disapproved ad
P2	% of auto fixes/ AI suggestions requiring subsequent manual edits

North Star Metric:

> **Accelerated Fix Rate**: % of rejected SMB ads approved within 2 hours of entering auto-fix workflow.

Risks & Counter-Metrics

Risk	Counter-Metric
Over-automation yielding incorrect fixes	Monitor % “not helpful” feedback; rollback low-rated fixes
Bad actors reverse-engineering policies	Track re-rejection rate post-auto-fix for gaming patterns
User overwhelm leading to churn	Measure step-by-step engagement; simplify UI if churn > 30%

In conclusion, helping well-intentioned SMB advertisers whose ads are disapproved due to policy violations presents a positive risk-reward balance, as it protects users while unlocking safe ads, drives advertiser growth, and generates revenue for Microsoft Advertising. An AI-powered auto-fix system supports this by transforming unclear rejections into clear, actionable guidance that speeds up SMB campaign approvals and success.